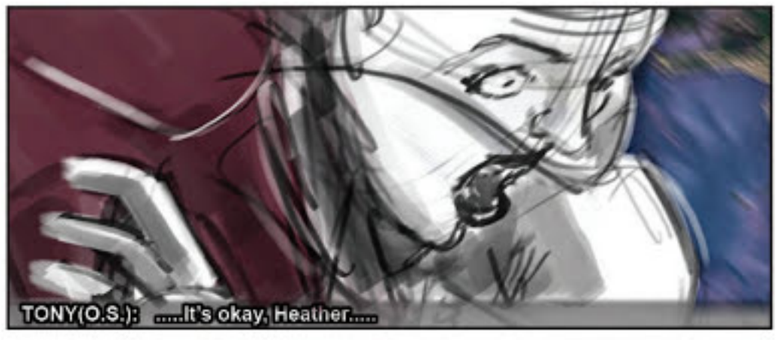






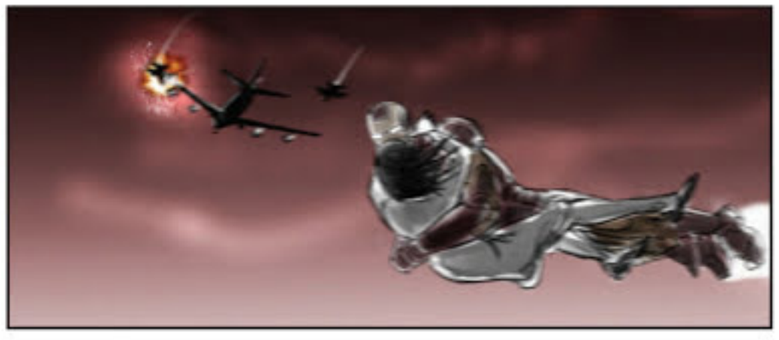












"The women had skirts on; the people were all different sizes. And of course you have to outfit all thirteen people at the same time, and have them appear to have no parachutes on! The actual parachutes could never be seen."

Second Unit Director Brian Smrz supervised the sequence: "We had a plan, but there were some things we weren't going to be able to do, so we had to suggest alternatives to get close to the previs. The actual skydive, for the 'Barrel of Monkeys' sequence, went relatively smoothly because Jeff put together a really incredible team, the Red Bull team of skydivers. Those guys are unbelievable."

An important preparation stage was the dirt-dive: an earthbound simulation of the diving moves required for the scene. "You're rehearsing your moves, but on the ground," Smrz explains. "The cameraman and everybody stands on the ground as if they're exiting the plane. The cameraman moves where he's going to go, and everyone moves around as if they're up in the sky. They'll sit there and watch that, talk about it and come up with a plan, and then they go up there and do it. It's never exactly what you planned just because of the dynamics of falling through the air, but they come pretty close. And then I reviewed the footage as soon as they landed, and we'd discuss what changes we could make, or we'd move on.

"We had a certain amount of time, so I only got one or two takes on each dive. Sometimes I'd take three tries if I thought something was important. But if I didn't get it in three at the most, I'd just punt and move on to something else. We knew we had a certain number of days, and we got lucky with the weather. So no real problems."